

Toddler Winter Gear Battles — Action Checklist

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PREP CAR SEAT SAFETY

- ☐ **Prep Car Seat Safety:** Perform the pinch test with your toddler wearing their winter coat in the car seat to identify dangerous harness slack — if you can pinch more than one finger's width after removing the coat, the coat is creating a false sense of security that could fail in a crash.
- ☐ **Prep Car Seat Safety:** Replace heavy coats with a thin full-zip micro-fleece that passes the two-finger clearance test at the chest clip — this allows safe warmth without compression risk during sudden stops or collisions.
- ☐ **Prep Car Seat Safety:** Pre-warm your car for 5 minutes before loading toddlers who resist cold vehicles so they arrive at daycare comfortably without needing bulky outer layers in the car seat.
- ☐ **Prep Car Seat Safety:** Place blankets only over a buckled child's lap and legs, never over the chest or arms — this keeps the lower body warm while maintaining proper harness positioning and effectiveness in a crash.

IMPLEMENT THE LAYER SYSTEM

- ☐ **Implement the Layer System:** Keep a spare thin fleece jacket in the car permanently so one is always available when your toddler refuses the one they're wearing or tracks mud onto it at daycare drop-off.
- ☐ **Implement the Layer System:** Pack the heavy winter coat, hat, and gloves in your arrival bag instead of wearing them to the car — put the heavy gear on at daycare, not before departure.
- ☐ **Implement the Layer System:** Invest in a car seat poncho that drapes over buckled shoulders with front snaps or Velcro so your toddler doesn't need to thread their arms through anything to stay warm during transfers.
- ☐ **Implement the Layer System:** Dress your toddler in a thin fleece before departure and apply the heavy coat only upon arrival at daycare to eliminate the in-and-out coat battles that waste your entire morning.

BUILD THE MORNING ROUTINE

- ☐ **Build the Morning Routine:** Create a visual morning schedule showing each step from waking to daycare arrival so your toddler knows what comes next and fights less when they can predict the sequence.

 - ☐ **Build the Morning Routine:** Let your toddler zip and unzip their own full-zip fleece jacket to satisfy their need for independence and reduce resistance to wearing it without a power struggle.

 - ☐ **Build the Morning Routine:** Discuss with daycare staff the car seat safety guidelines about removing heavy coats before car rides and ask if they can help your child apply heavy gear upon arrival.

 - ☐ **Build the Morning Routine:** Maintain consistent gear boundaries every morning even when you're running late because inconsistency confuses toddlers and makes future morning battles harder to resolve.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.